known. This annual average is lower than it was under both of Netanyahu's predecessors, the right-wing Ariel Sharon and the center-left Ehud Olmert.

The reluctance to approve major new construction has been a constant source of tension between the settlers and the Netanyahu government, which depends heavily on their support. The prime minister frequently blamed the slow pace of housing starts on Barack Obama. For all their personal animosity, the American president was an invaluable asset to Netanyahu, who invoked his name in cabinet meetings like a stern father warning unruly children about the boogeyman. A building spree in the West Bank, he advised, could bring consequences from Washington: an unfavorable military aid package, perhaps, or reduced support at the United Nations. His ministers usually fell in line. Yet the rank-and-file of the settler movement wasn't convinced. This is what gave rise to the "price tag" phenomenon.

Jews on Jews

The residents of Yitzhar and neighboring settlements largely belong to the national-religious movement. In the 2015 election, nearly three-quarters of Yitzhar's votes went to Yachad, an extremist party that ultimately failed to clear the threshold to enter the Knesset. (One of the candidates on Yachad's list believes homosexuality is a disease; another was charged with assaulting a Palestinian shortly before the election.) About 20 per cent of the vote went to the Jewish Home, the mainstream political vehicle for the settlers. Likud received exactly eight votes. It narrowly edged out the pro-marijuana legalization party, which got four.

One of the many divisions within the national-religious camp revolves around the concept of *mamlachtiyut*, a word that is roughly translated as "statism". The vast majority of national-religious Israelis belong to the *mamlachti* trend: they often disagree with Israeli policy, but they accept it, because it is the consensus decision of a Jewish government. A minority, however, subscribe to an anti-*mamlachti* worldview, which holds that certain actions—dividing the land of Israel, for example—are beyond the pale. An Israeli government that pursues them is also illegitimate and should be opposed, often passively, but occasionally with violence. The assassination of Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin in 1995 was the most extreme manifestation of this ideology. (Readers familiar with the Arab